SPACE

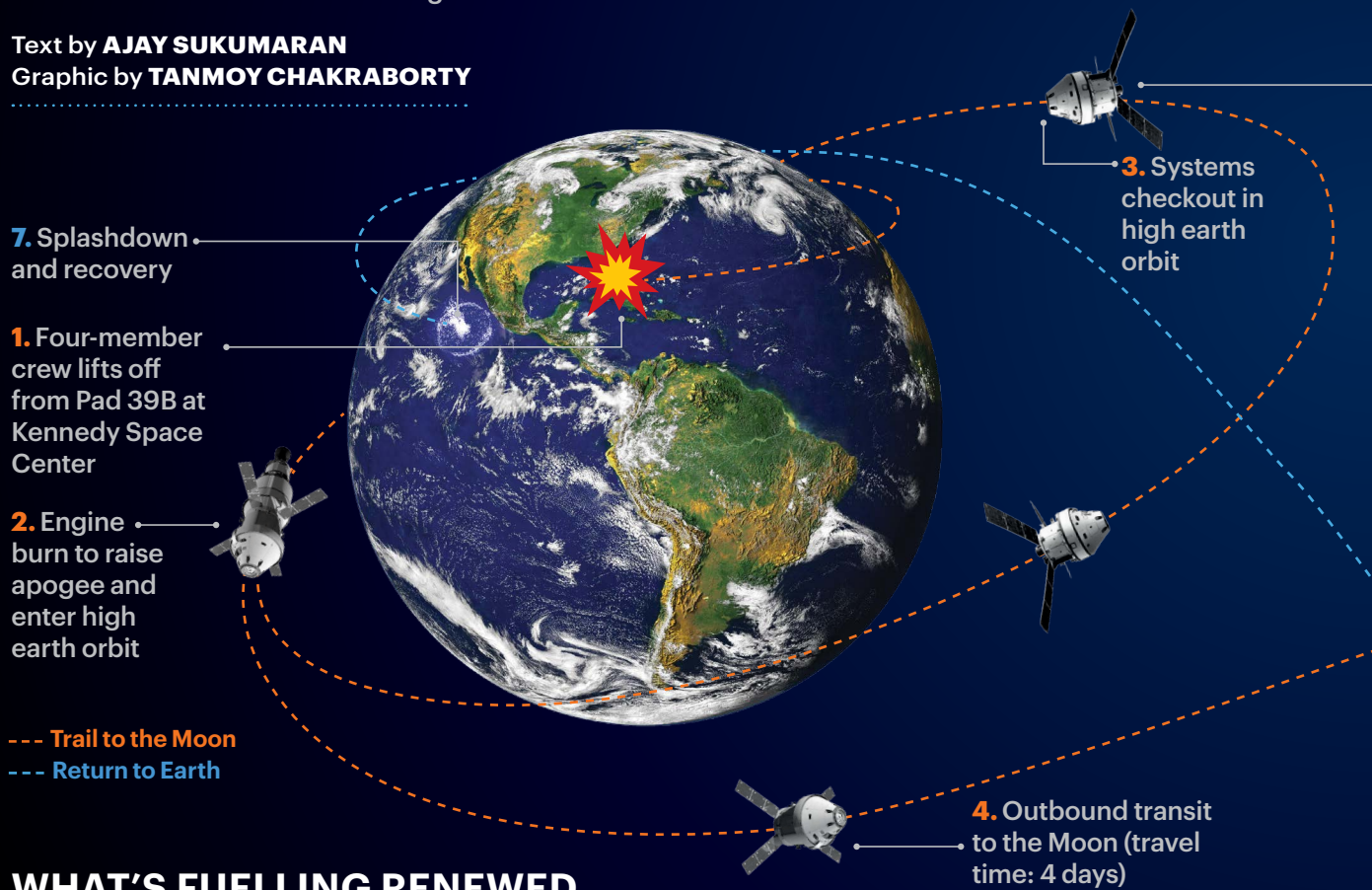
REACHING FOR THE MOON

All eyes are on Artemis II, NASA's pivotal lunar mission, whose planned March launch has been pushed back owing to a technical glitch. An April window remains open, pending repairs. When it takes off, the mission will send humans to the Moon for the first time in more than 50 years—though only on a fly-by, looping the lunar far side before returning. The delay has also forced NASA to radically alter its ambitious roadmap for an eventual moon landing, in favour of a step-by-step approach. The last crewed lunar voyage was in 1972, at the height of the Cold War space race. India and China rekindled momentum with a string of robotic missions in the new millennium. What is driving this new race to the Moon?

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In Greek mythology, Artemis is a goddess associated with the Moon and the twin sister of Apollo, the Sun god



WHAT'S FUELLING RENEWED INTEREST IN THE MOON

GEOPOLITICS

Costly and technologically demanding, lunar missions signal advanced capability and, increasingly, ambitions of power and strategic access to lunar resources

SCIENCE

These missions enable the study of the solar system's formation, the Moon's role in life on Earth, and biological and physical processes in low gravity

DEEP SPACE EXPLORATION

The Moon is viewed as a staging post for deep space missions. For instance, water ice in permanently shadowed craters at its South Pole could sustain astronauts and be split into hydrogen and oxygen for rocket fuel